THE MOST VALUABLE AI SKILL IS SAYING NO

Screening AI use cases for real return.

DUSTIN T HUGHES · VP of Technology, Laborde Products NOAI 2026 · Friday, Nov 13, 2026 · 2:30–4:00 PM · Education Center, New Orleans Jazz Museum

EXERCISE 1 · 10 MINUTES

INVENTORY TWO WEEKS OF REAL WORK.

1 What did you do more than twice?	**2** What did you copy from one place to another?	**3** What did you wait on?	**4** What did you dread?

	TASK	HOW OFTEN	MINUTES EACH TIME	WHO DOES IT
01				
02				
03				
04				
05				
06				
07				
08				
09				
10				
11				
12				

EXERCISE 2 · 5 MINUTES

PICK THREE.

A One you’d love to pitch

B One that’s boring

C One you’d be embarrassed to bring up

EXERCISE 3 · 10 MINUTES

FOUR GATES.

Run your three through the gates.

Start with the minutes, then take the gates in order. Stop at the first NO.

ONE COLUMN EACH A number on a dashed line is a default: a rate or a house rule. Cross it out and write your own.	EXAMPLE Invoice follow-up reminders	A One you'd love to pitch	B One that's boring	C One you'd be embarrassed to bring up

START HERE **THE MINUTES** *Minutes are the raw material. Money is what they turn into.*

RULE OF THUMB A minute a week is $25 a year.

Minutes saved each time × times a week	*6 × 60*	MIN / TIMES	MIN / TIMES	MIN / TIMES
= minutes a week × $25 = return At $30 an hour and 50 weeks. At $60 an hour, × $50.	*$9,000* *360 × $25*	MIN / $ A YEAR	MIN / $ A YEAR	MIN / $ A YEAR
Service business: is this larger? Hours freed a year × share turned into paid work × margin.	—	$ IF LARGER, USE THIS	$ IF LARGER, USE THIS	$ IF LARGER, USE THIS

GATE 1 COST *What does it cost to run?*

HOUSE RULE NO when yearly cost is more than 30% of yearly return.

What runs it? Circle one. Beside each: the price of 1,000 runs.*	*$0.45* *Small model*	Don't automate — / Spreadsheet about $0 / Plain code about $0 / Small model $0.45 / Frontier model $36	Don't automate — / Spreadsheet about $0 / Plain code about $0 / Small model $0.45 / Frontier model $36	Don't automate — / Spreadsheet about $0 / Plain code about $0 / Small model $0.45 / Frontier model $36
To run it for a year Times a week × 50, in thousands, × the price you circled.	*$1.35* *3 × $0.45*	$	$	$
+ tools and licences = cost a year Dollars a month × 12, added to the line above.	*$1.35* *$1.35 + $0*	$ TOOLS / $ COST	$ TOOLS / $ COST	$ TOOLS / $ COST

GATE 2 RETURN *What comes back: cash sooner, or more work done?*

HOUSE RULE NO when yearly return is under $5,000 and the task does not touch the cash path.

On the cash path? Days faster? quote → order → pick → ship → invoice → collect. One day off the cycle frees about one day of sales.	*yes* *2 days faster*	☐ YES / DAYS FASTER	☐ YES / DAYS FASTER	☐ YES / DAYS FASTER

GATE 3 EFFORT *What does it take to build it and keep it alive?*

HOUSE RULE NO when payback is longer than 26 weeks. That is half a year: a one-time cost above half of what is left over is a NO.

Build and rollout hours × $75 The one-time cost.	*$2,250* *30 × $75*	HOURS / $	HOURS / $	HOURS / $
Upkeep hours a month × $900 12 months at $75 an hour: upkeep for a year.	*$1,350* *1.5 × $900*	HOURS / $	HOURS / $	HOURS / $
= left over a year Return − cost − upkeep. None left: it never pays back.	*$7,649*	$	$	$
Payback, in weeks One-time cost divided by (left over divided by 52).	*about 15 weeks*	WEEKS	WEEKS	WEEKS

GATE 4 POTENTIAL *If it works, how far does it grow?*

HOUSE RULE NO when growth is below 1× or nobody owns the freed time.

How many times bigger in a year? 1 = the same size · 1.5 = half again · 2 = double	*1.5×*	TIMES BIGGER	TIMES BIGGER	TIMES BIGGER
Who owns the freed time? A named person who decides what it becomes.	*named*	A NAME	A NAME	A NAME

VERDICT

Circle PASS or NO at each gate. Any NO and it is out: stop there, and leave the gates after it empty.

passes all four

COST	RETURN	EFFORT	POTENTIAL
PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
NO	NO	NO	NO

COST	RETURN	EFFORT	POTENTIAL
PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
NO	NO	NO	NO

COST	RETURN	EFFORT	POTENTIAL
PASS	PASS	PASS	PASS
NO	NO	NO	NO

THE MATH PICKS

More than one left? The highest two-year value wins: (return − cost) × (1 + growth) − one-time − 2 × upkeep.

$17,547
two-year value

* List prices for one run of 2,000 tokens in and 500 out (about a page and a half read, a few paragraphs written). Small model: Claude Haiku 5.5. Frontier model: Claude Fable 5.2. Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026. The example column is made up, to show the sums.

THE LADDER OF TOOLS

Don't automate · Spreadsheet formula · Plain code · Small model · Frontier model · Agent

THE WAYPOINT STANDARD

A win only counts with the task, the prompt, the output, and the time saved.

Climb only as far as the task makes you.